

Kai Wu

Postdoctoral Researcher in Computational Astrophysics

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RESEARCH PROFILE

Computational astrophysicist specializing in collisional stellar dynamics and direct N-body simulations of dense stellar systems. Research spans massive star clusters, compact-object populations, Population III clusters, and the dynamical evolution of planetary systems in cluster environments. Developer and code administrator of NBODY6++GPU, with experience in million-body simulations, heterogeneous GPU supercomputing, and large-scale simulation-data analysis.

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Postdoctoral Researcher, Astronomisches Rechen-Institut (ARI-ZAH), Heidelberg University, Germany **2024-present**

- Lead and analyse direct N-body simulations of globular, nuclear, and Population III star clusters within the DRAGON-III programme.
- Develop coupled methods for planetary-system evolution in dense stellar environments using NBODY6++GPU and REBOUND.
- Maintain scientific software and simulation workflows across heterogeneous CPU/GPU supercomputing systems.

EDUCATION

PhD in Mathematical Sciences, University of Liverpool, UK

2019-2024

Thesis: Dynamical stability of debris discs with planets in star clusters

- Supervisor: Prof. M. B. N. Kouwenhoven; research conducted off-site at Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University (XJTLU).
- Full scholarship covering tuition and stipend.

BSc in Physics, Nankai University, China

2015-2019

Thesis: Dynamical evolution of young open clusters in the solar neighbourhood

- Supervisor: Prof. Fang Bo; cumulative GPA: 85.3/100.
- Graduation thesis awarded Excellent Thesis (top 3%).

RESEARCH AND SOFTWARE CONTRIBUTIONS

DRAGON-III and dense stellar systems: million-body simulations of globular and nuclear star clusters over cosmic time; rotating and extremely massive Population III clusters; compact objects and multi-messenger observables.

Planetary systems in clusters: dynamical stability of debris discs and planets, survival of planetary architectures along stellar orbits, and long-term evolution of free-floating minor bodies.

NBODY6++GPU developer and lead maintainer: code developer since 2022; introduced Git-based development and CI testing; manage pull requests, issues, documentation, and user support.

Numerical-method development: implemented Fortran routines for planetary-system evolution and C/C++ interfaces for high-performance management of REBOUND simulations.

HPC and data: large-scale production management, failure diagnosis, restart validation, and reproducibility of long-running MPI/GPU simulations. Simulation and benchmarking experience on JUPITER, JUWELS, LUMI, Dongfang, Silkroad, and Kepler; CUDA/HIP platforms; analysis of more than 100 TB of DRAGON simulation data.

Numerical verification and simulation reliability: develop independent reference calculations, finite-difference and convergence tests, end-to-end validation workflows, and guarded production checks for direct N-body simulations and Galactic-potential implementations.

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed journal articles

- [1] Kai Wu, Ataru Tanikawa, Francesco Flammini Dotti, Marcelo C. Vergara, Vahid Amiri, Boyuan Liu, Albrecht W. H. Kamlah, Manuel Arca Sedda, Nadine Neumayer, and Rainer Spurzem. "Direct N-body simulations of rotating and extremely massive Population III star clusters." *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 709, A142 (2026). [doi:10.1051/0004-6361/202558659](#)
- [2] Francesco Flammini Dotti, M. B. N. Kouwenhoven, Kai Wu, Abbas Askar, Peter Berczik, Mirek Giersz, Rainer Spurzem, and Ian Dobbs-Dixon. "Dynamical evolution of massless particles in star clusters with NBODY6++GPU-MASSLESS: II. The long-term evolution of free-floating comets." *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 706, A219 (2026). [doi:10.1051/0004-6361/202557334](#)
- [3] Guimei Liu, Yu Zhang, Jing Zhong, Li Chen, Xiangcun Meng, and Kai Wu. "Formation and evolution of new primordial open cluster groups: Feedback-driven star formation." *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 696, A117 (2025). [doi:10.1051/0004-6361/202452774](#)
- [4] Songmei Qin, Jing Zhong, Tong Tang, Yueyue Jiang, Long Wang, Kai Wu, Friedrich Anders, Lola Balaguer-Nunez, Guimei Liu, Chunyan Li, Jinliang Hou, and Li Chen. "Unveiling the binary nature of NGC 2323." *Astronomy & Astrophysics*, 693, A317 (2025). [doi:10.1051/0004-6361/202452962](#)
- [5] Kai Wu, M. B. N. Kouwenhoven, Francesco Flammini Dotti, and Rainer Spurzem. "Influence of planets on debris discs in star clusters - II. The impact of stellar density." *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 533(4) (2024). [doi:10.1093/mnras/stae2067](#)

- [6] **Kai Wu**, M. B. N. Kouwenhoven, Rainer Spurzem, and Xiaoying Pang. "Influence of planets on debris discs in star clusters - I. The 50 au Jupiter." *Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society*, 523(4) (2023). [doi:10.1093/mnras/stad1673](https://doi.org/10.1093/mnras/stad1673)

Accepted conference proceeding

- [7] M. B. N. Kouwenhoven et al. (including **Kai Wu**). "Planetary systems in dense stellar environments." *Journal of Physics: Conference Series*, 1523, 012011 (2020). [doi:10.1088/1742-6596/1523/1/012011](https://doi.org/10.1088/1742-6596/1523/1/012011)
- [8] **Kai Wu**, Philip Cho, Rainer Spurzem, Long Wang, Francesco Flammini Dotti, and Vahid Amiri. "DRAGON-III simulations: modelling million-body globular and nuclear star clusters over cosmic time." *Proceedings of IAU Symposium 398*, arXiv:2510.03933
- [9] Philip Cho, **Kai Wu**, Francesco Flammini Dotti, Taras Panamarev, and Rainer Spurzem. "Modeling Tidal Disruption Events and Compact Object Plunges in Nuclear Star Clusters." *Proceedings of IAU Symposium 398*, arXiv:2602.08574.
- [10] Yuzhe Song, Debatri Chattopadhyay, Jarrod Hurley, Rainer Spurzem, Francesco Flammini Dotti, and **Kai Wu**. "Modelling Millisecond Pulsar Populations in Globular Clusters with NBODY6++GPU." *Proceedings of IAU Symposium 398*, arXiv:2511.08850.

Manuscripts in preparation

- [11] **Kai Wu**, Francesco Flammini Dotti, Marcelo C. Vergara, Vahid Amiri, and Rainer Spurzem. "DRAGON-III simulation - I. Multi-messenger observations in the computer and comparison with observed astrophysical objects." . *In preparation*
- [12] **Kai Wu**, M. B. N. Kouwenhoven, Rainer Spurzem, and Francesco Flammini Dotti. "Linking the survivability of planets in star clusters with the orbits of their host stars." . *In preparation*

HONOURS, AWARDS, AND COMPETITIVE SUPPORT

\$360 equivalent, ICISE, accommodation support for conference Modelling and Observing Dense Star Clusters.	2026
€1,500, Young Researcher and Innovator Conference Grant, COST Action CA22133. Awarded to present at the European Astronomical Society Annual Meeting.	2025
€450, Travel Grant, Astronomische Gesellschaft. Support to present two talks at the Annual Meeting of AG.	2025
Excellent Teaching Assistant Award (top 2%), XJTLU	2023
Best Oral Presentation Award (top 5%), XJTLU Postgraduate Research Symposium	2022
Best Poster Award (top 5%), XJTLU Postgraduate Research Symposium	2021
Full-scholarship PhD, tuition waiver and stipend, XJTLU	2019-2023
Excellent Graduation Thesis (top 3%), Nankai University	2019
Boling and university scholarships, Nankai University	2015-2017
Second Prize (top 10%), Nankai Physicists' Tournament	2016

INVITED LECTURES AND SEMINARS

ARI-ZAH, Heidelberg University: From Debris Disks to Million-Body Clusters: Planetary Perturbations, Stellar Interactions, and DRAGON-III	Jul. 2025
Zhejiang University: Dynamics of debris discs with planets in star clusters	Oct. 2024
KIAA-Peking University: Dynamics of debris discs in star clusters	Jul. 2023
Shanghai Astronomical Observatory: An in-depth introduction to numerical star-cluster simulations,	Jul. 2023
Shanghai Astronomical Observatory: 30-hour doctoral course of N-body simulations with NBODY6++GPU	Aug. 2023
Spurzem's International Seminar: Git and GitHub for NBODY6++GPU development and collaboration	Apr. 2022

SELECTED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Annual Meeting of the German Astronomical Society, Goerlitz - two contributed talks on DRAGON-III and planetary systems in star clusters	Sep. 2025
European Astronomical Society Annual Meeting, Cork - Dynamical stability of debris discs with planets in star clusters	Jun. 2025
IAU Symposium 398 / MODEST-25, Seoul - DRAGON-III million-body globular and nuclear star clusters	Jun. 2025
Gas Accretion in Planet Formation, MPIA - Star clusters, protoplanetary discs, and debris-disc evolution	Mar. 2025
12th Kazakhstan-China-Korea Workshop, Astana - Dynamical stability of debris discs with planets in star clusters	May 2024
SPP 1992 Final Colloquium, Berlin - Dynamical evolution of planetary systems in star clusters	Mar. 2024
Star Cluster Workshop: From Observations to Simulations, Suzhou - Debris discs and open-cluster evolution	Oct. 2023
Annual Meeting of the Chinese Astronomical Society, Weihai - Cluster environments and debris discs	Aug. 2023
Structure, Formation and Evolution of Star Clusters, Sun Yat-sen University - Planetary systems in clusters	Jun. 2023
5th Young Scientist Forum of Planetary Science, Sanya - The 50 au Jupiter	Mar. 2023
PFE-SPP 1992 Joint Meeting, online - Planets and debris particles in star clusters	Sep. 2023

TEACHING AND ACADEMIC TRAINING

Associate Fellow of the Higher Education Academy (AFHEA) , Advance HE	2024
- Teaching qualification aligned with the UK Professional Standards Framework.	
Part-time Lecturer - IB Calculus , Suzhou Research Institute of Xi'an Jiaotong University	Jan.-Jul. 2022
- Designed and delivered 105 hours of calculus instruction for an international high-school preparatory programme.	
Teaching Assistant / Tutor , Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University	2019-2023
- Delivered approximately 30 hours of English-language teaching in physics experiments, calculus, advanced linear algebra, and statistical methods.	
- Received the School of Mathematics and Physics Excellent Teaching Assistant Award (top 2%).	

Invited Instructor - Doctoral N-body Course, Shanghai Astronomical Observatory

Aug. 2023

- Delivered a 30-hour practical course on simulating star clusters with NBODY6++GPU.

Invited Tutorial Instructor, Spurzem's International Seminar

Apr. 2022

- Delivered a four-hour tutorial on Git, GitHub, and collaborative scientific-software development.

ACADEMIC SERVICE AND MEMBERSHIPS

Referee, Astronomy & Astrophysics	2026-present
Referee, Planetary and Space Science	2025-present
Member, COST Action CA22133 "The Birth of Solar Systems"	2023-present
Member, Silk Road Project for stellar dynamics and computational astrophysics	2019-present

SELECTED ACADEMIC VISITS

National Astronomical Observatories of China and KIAA-Peking University - visitor of Dr. Shuo Li	Dec. 2024; Jun. 2025;
Frankfurt Institute for Advanced Studies - visitor of Prof. Volker Lindenstruth	Jan. 2025
Heidelberg University - guest researcher funded by DFG SPP 1992	Mar.-Apr. 2024
National Astronomical Observatories of China - visiting scholar funded by XJTLU	Dec. 2019
CITA, University of Toronto - visiting student of Prof. Yanqin Wu	Jul.-Oct. 2018
Space Telescope Science Institute / Johns Hopkins University - visiting student of Prof. Christine Chen	Jun.-Sep. 2017
Earlier visits: Purple Mountain Observatory; National University of Singapore; Nanyang Technological University	2016

TECHNICAL EXPERTISE**Scientific programming:** Python, Fortran, C/C++, Bash; NumPy, SciPy, pandas, multiprocessing**Parallel and GPU computing:** MPI, OpenMP, CUDA, HIP; heterogeneous CPU/GPU systems**AI-assisted research:** tool-enabled LLM coding/research agents for scientific software, numerical verification, HPC debugging, and research automation, with test- and physics-based validation. Multi-agent orchestration.**Scientific software:** NBODY6++GPU, PeTar, REBOUND, MERCURY**Data and visualisation:** HDF5, Matplotlib, Plotly; large-scale simulation-data processing**Development workflows:** Git, GitHub, CI/CD, Docker, documentation, issue and release management**Typesetting and reproducibility:** LaTeX, Linux-based research workflows**ACADEMIC REFERENCES**Prof. Mattheus Bartholomeus Nicolaas Kouwenhoven t.kouwenhoven@xjtlu.edu.cn

Professor; Head of department at XJTLU

Mathematical Sciences Department, Xi'an Jiaotong- Liverpool University, Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University (XJTLU)

Prof Rainer Spurzem spurzem@ari.uni-heidelberg.de spurzem@nao.cas.cn

apl. Professor at Astronomisches Rechen-Institut: Zentrum für Astronomie (ARI-ZAH) in University of Heidelberg

Prof. Peter Berczik berczik@camk.edu.pl

Professor at Nicolaus Copernicus Astronomical Centre of the Polish Academy of Sciences

Dr. Francesco Flammini Dotti ff2415@nyu.edu

Post-doctoral researcher at the Department of Physics and the Center of Astrophysics and Space science, New York University Abu Dhabi